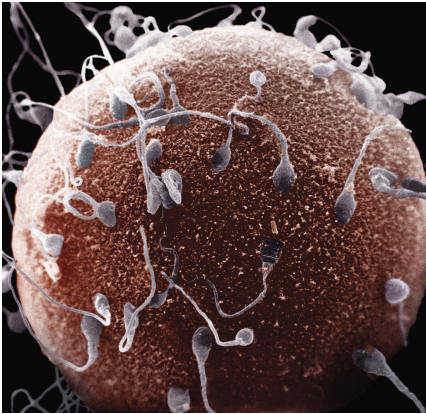




YOU ARE **2 WEEKS AND 1 DAY**

265 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

Here the egg is shown surrounded by sperm. Although only one sperm will fertilize the egg, several hundred are thought to be necessary to break down its defensive layers and enable fertilization to take place.

“Your newly released egg will only survive 24 hours, but hopefully in that time it will meet sperm and be fertilized.”

You are likely to have ovulated and your unfertilized egg now begins its journey. Once it has been released by the ovary, the egg is swept up by one of your fallopian tubes and, moving in the direction of the uterus, comes to rest in the widest portion of the tube, awaiting fertilization.

It is no exaggeration to say that for each sperm released the chance of even reaching the site of fertilization is in the order of one in a million. Around 300 sperm reach the tube but only one will fertilize the egg. Once the sperm has penetrated, it triggers a reaction that makes the surface impenetrable. Each sperm and egg contain 23 chromosomes, half of the total genetic material required. The egg will always contain an X chromosome but the sperm will carry either an X or Y chromosome and therefore determines the sex of the embryo. The sperm and egg chromosomes combine forming the “zygote” and fertilization is complete.

The hormones responsible for the production of sperm are released every 60 to 90 minutes. So a man is constantly producing sperm cells. In theory, this means that a male is always fertile, but it takes sperm a 72-day period to fully develop. So leading an unhealthy lifestyle during that time will impinge on the quality. For this reason, if you're trying to conceive, your partner should embark on a healthy lifestyle for two to three months to produce good sperm.